
The Morning: The jobs report

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The New York Times The Morning

March 6, 2026



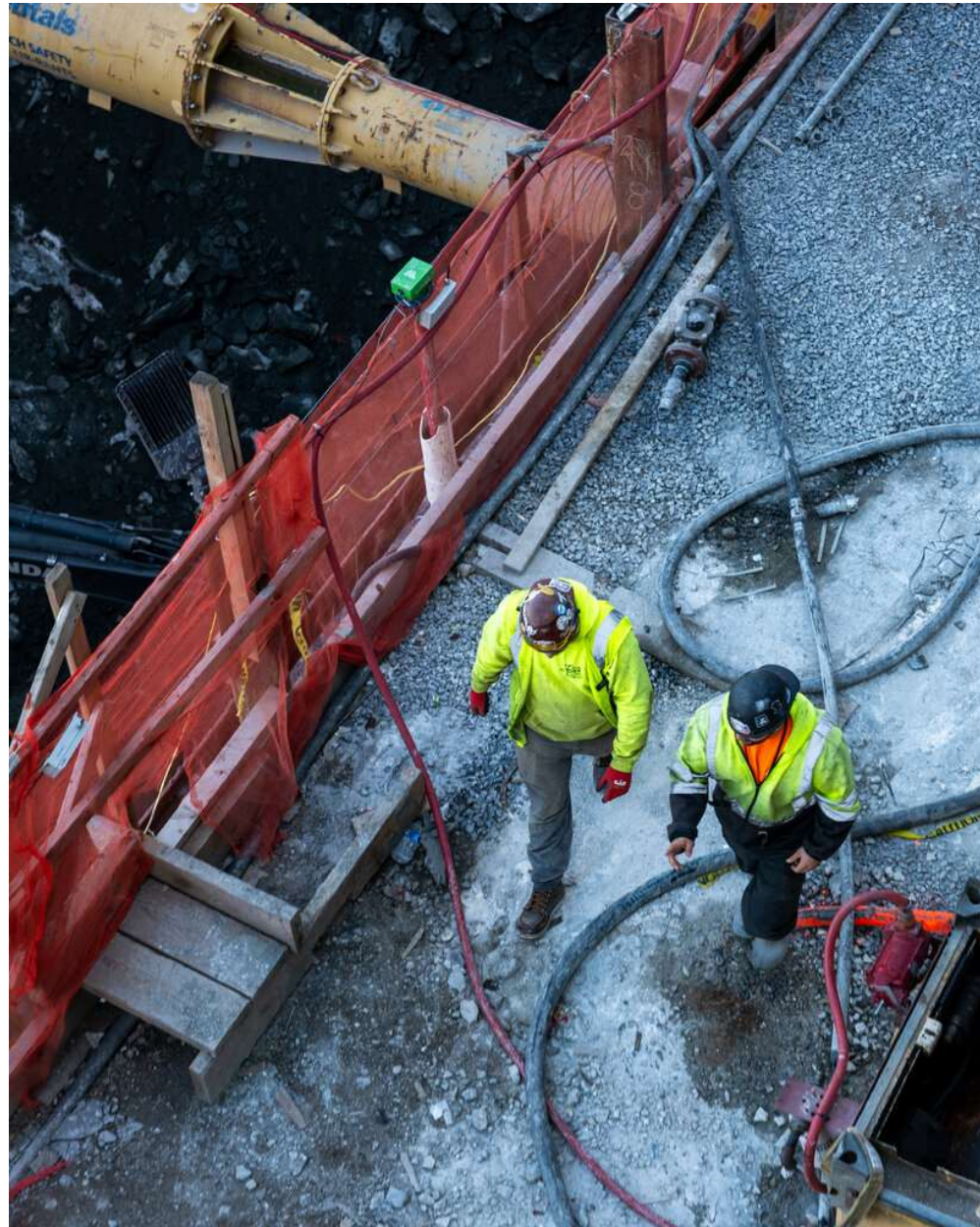
By Sam Sifton

Good morning. Missiles are flying across the Middle East. Israel is pounding both Beirut and Tehran with strikes, and Iran is targeting Tel Aviv. Thousands of people are fleeing. [We have all the latest updates here.](#)

And President Trump fired Kristi Noem, his homeland security secretary. She's been in the spotlight for months — wearing a Rolex watch and self-promoting as she oversaw Trump's immigration crackdown. But after she drew even Republican frustration this week for comments before

Congress, Trump announced he would replace her. [Read about her rise and fall.](#)

There's more news below. I'm going to start today, though, with the economy.



Spencer Platt/Getty Images

The dark economy

News doesn't generally frustrate me. It can be good or bad, thrilling, expected or disturbing, but for the most part it doesn't leave me on the cusp of annoyance.

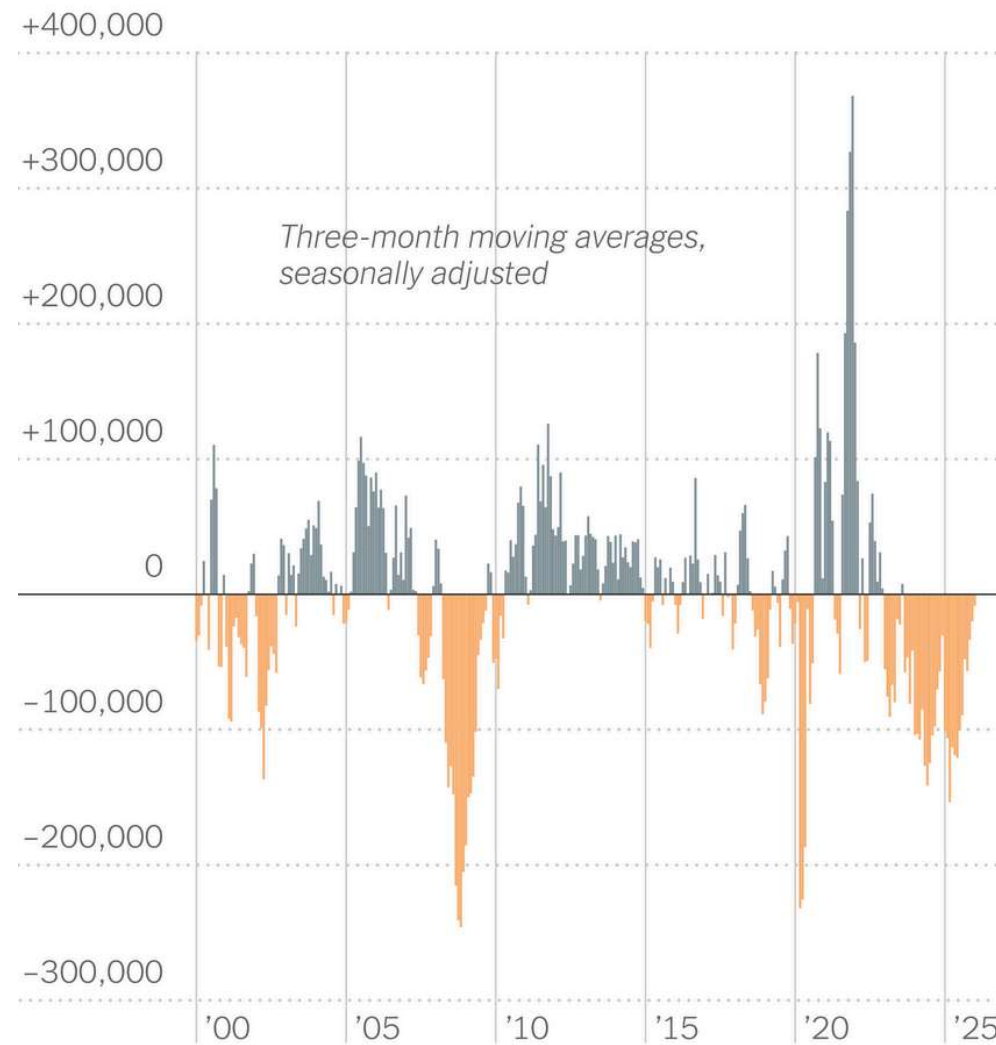
The jobs reports that the Bureau of Labor Statistics releases every month are an exception. They can be exasperating! Last July, for instance, the report said the U.S. had added 147,000 jobs in June. That was good news. But in August that number was revised to less than a tenth of that. Not such good news?

And then last month, the June data changed again, offering bad news.

Employment actually *declined* by 20,000 jobs in June. Job growth over the past two years had been overstated by nearly one million positions.

Job growth revisions

The Bureau of Labor Statistics often revises its estimate by many thousands. Recent adjustments have been consistently downward.



Note: Data is based on net revisions from the first to the latest estimate and includes the annual benchmark revisions when available. Source: Bureau of Labor Statistics. Karl Russell/The New York Times

We'll see the February jobs report in a couple of hours. But does it matter what it says if the government's just going to revise the number later?

That's a question Ben Casselman, the chief economics correspondent for The Times, gets a lot. And he answered it this morning in a story about the jobs numbers that you could distill into an axiom: *Context matters*.

As one economist told him, "Any one number can shift your understanding." But there's always underlying detail to examine as well, along with other data that helps paint a clearer picture of what's actually happening in the economy — consumer spending, say, or economic anxiety, inflation, even the stock market.

The monthly jobs data last year, Ben wrote, mostly showed the labor market stuck in "low-hire, low-fire" equilibrium: Employers added few jobs but didn't lay off many employees. And the revisions didn't really change that story.

Bias-free numbers

If I've found the jobs reports frustrating, Trump has found them infuriating. After the revisions last summer, he fired the head of the Bureau of Labor Statistics, accusing her without evidence of cooking the books to make his administration look bad.

Economists overwhelmingly dismissed the charge. After all, there were downward revisions during the Biden presidency, too. But Democrats worry that Trump will now pressure the bureau into producing data that he likes. There is no evidence that's happening, Ben wrote:

Current and former staffers say that the agency is using the same procedures as under past administrations, and that it would be

impossible for the White House to interfere in its operations without detection.

Reasons for worry

Whether the data is reliable, though, remains a complicated question to answer. Last month's report said employers added just 181,000 jobs in 2025. That was 69 percent fewer than its initial estimate of 584,000. There was a downward revision a year earlier that was nearly as large.

Ben explained why that happened:

Economists are optimistic that the big revisions are at least partly the result of temporary factors and that the data will become more reliable going forward. The Covid-19 pandemic led to waves of business openings and closures, which are difficult for the government to track in real time, and upended the seasonal patterns that statisticians try to account for in their estimates. The surge in immigration in the early years of the Biden administration, and the sharp decline later in his term and under Mr. Trump, have broken models that were built for much more gradual demographic shifts.

They're optimistic but guarded, Ben reports. Budgets are shrinking, as is the size of the agency. Response rates to the surveys that make up the bulk of the data are declining. And government shutdowns don't help, either.

"There's good reason to be concerned that the quality of our statistics is going to deteriorate," another economist said. "Even before this administration, there

was reason to be concerned. The agencies have been fighting an uphill battle for years.”

Still, [Ben explains here](#) why it’s important not to dismiss the numbers. He’s convincing. Now I’m looking forward to seeing the new ones later this morning.



‘WAR’ IN IRAN?



After a strike in Tehran yesterday. Atta Kenare/Agence France-Presse — Getty Images

Trump has had no qualms with using the word “war” to describe the fighting between the U.S., Israel and Iran. “We’re doing very well on the war front,” he told reporters this week. Not so for many others in his party. Republicans on Capitol Hill have [contorted themselves to avoid the word](#), Annie Karni writes, calling it a “major combat operation,” a “mission” and “hostilities.”

Why? “We haven’t declared war,” said Senator Markwayne Mullin, Republican of Oklahoma and Trump’s new selection to lead homeland security. If Trump is waging war without congressional say-so, he might be acting outside constitutional boundaries. When a reporter reminded Mullin that he had used the word himself, he replied, “That was a misspoke.”

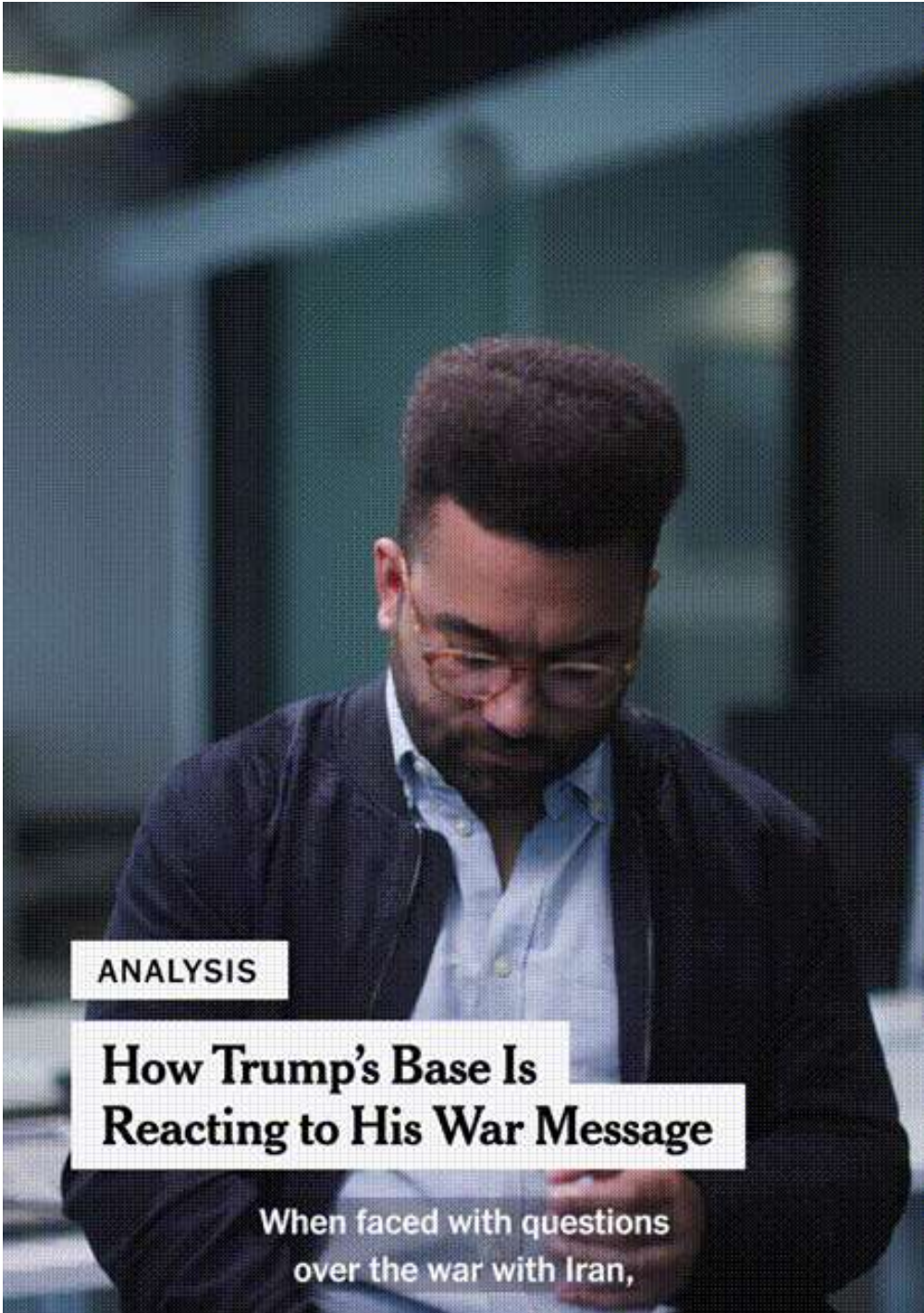
More on Trump’s power

Trump said that he should have a role in choosing Iran’s new leader and that Mojtaba Khamenei, a son of the slain ayatollah who has emerged as a front-runner, [would be an “unacceptable” choice](#).

The House, like the Senate, [voted down an effort](#) to halt the war against Iran and force Trump to go to Congress for authorization.

Presidents have long sidestepped Congress to launch limited military strikes. But Trump’s unilateral decision to start a war against Iran [sets a new precedent for presidential power](#), Charlie Savage writes.

How is Trump’s base responding to his administration’s conflicting messages on the war? In the video below, Zolan Kanno-Youngs explains. Click to play.

A man with dark skin, a beard, and glasses is looking down at a device in his hands. He is wearing a dark jacket over a light blue button-down shirt. The background is a blurred indoor setting with glass partitions and a ceiling light.

ANALYSIS

How Trump's Base Is Reacting to His War Message

When faced with questions
over the war with Iran,



The New York Times

More on strikes

The strike that hit an elementary school in the first hours of the war killed at least 175 people, many of them children, Iranian officials say. An investigation by The Times found [evidence that the U.S. was likely responsible.](#)

Two more schools in Iran appeared to have been damaged during the [bombing campaign from the United States and Israel.](#)

Intentional attacks on schools, hospitals and other civilian structures are considered war crimes.

Iranian Kurdish militants based in Iraq are preparing for a [possible attack on Iran.](#) ([Read about the Kurds](#), an ethnic group spread across the Middle East.)

THE LATEST NEWS

Kristi Noem



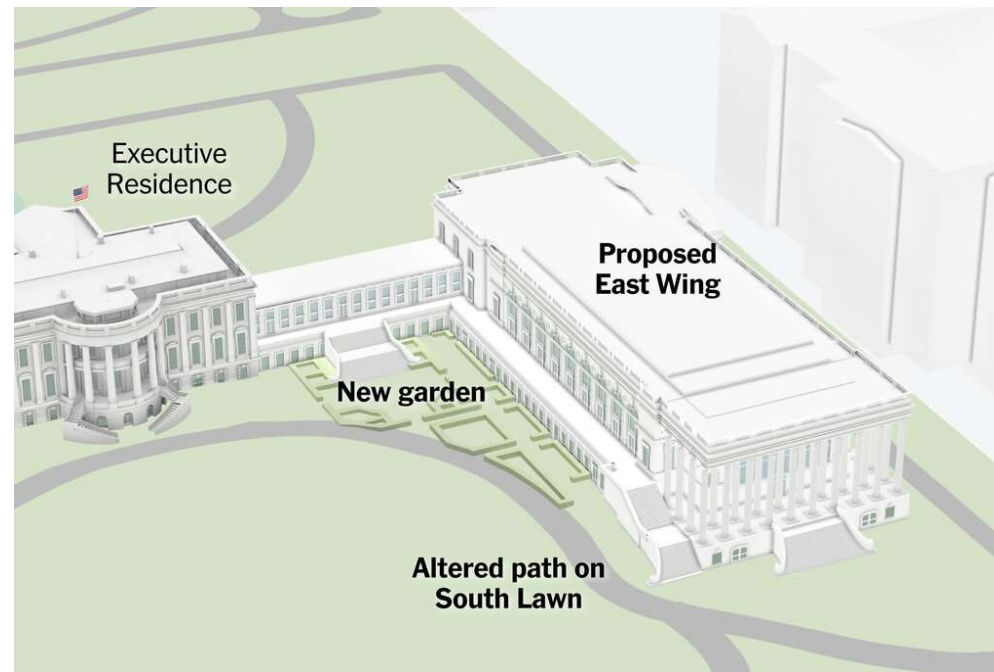
Kristi Noem this week. Tierney L. Cross/The New York Times

Trump said he would replace Noem with [Senator Markwayne Mullin](#), who is a staunch defender of the administration's mass deportation campaign.

Noem is the first cabinet member to be fired in Trump's second term.

The catalyst for Noem's firing appeared to be congressional hearings this week, in which lawmakers grilled her about a multimillion-dollar ad campaign that featured her heavily. She testified that Trump had approved it, but he [told Reuters](#) that was not true.

Politics



The New York Times

Trump's ballroom will change the appearance of the White House considerably. The Times modeled the new structure. [Click here to see it from different angles.](#)

The Defense Department has officially labeled Anthropic, an artificial intelligence company, [a "supply chain risk,"](#) which could prevent it from

doing business with the U.S. government.

Courts keep ordering the Trump administration to pay for congressional priorities, yet the administration continues to withhold the money.

[Here's how.](#)

The U.S. State Department [announced the re-establishment](#) of diplomatic and consular relations with Venezuela.

Around the World

Mexico is cracking down on cartels in response to American pressure.

[Our correspondents explain why that will be hard.](#)

Venezuela: A U.S. traveler set out to visit every country in South America. In Venezuela, he said, he was [detained, starved and beaten](#).

South Africa: President Cyril Ramaphosa [spoke with The Times](#) about Trump and racism. “I just thought that he is so uninformed, truly uninformed,” Ramaphosa said of Trump’s view of South Africa.

Other Big Stories

Three women were found dead in Utah, two on a hiking trail and one at a home. The police [arrested a suspect](#) who they said drove a victim's vehicle out of the state during the killing spree.

A study found that prescriptions for acetaminophen — the active ingredient in Tylenol — for pregnant women in emergency rooms dropped for weeks after Trump [claimed the painkiller could cause autism](#).

OPINIONS



Anna Malina Zemlianski

The TV series “Love Story,” about the relationship between John F. Kennedy Jr. and Carolyn Bessette Kennedy, depicts the actress **Daryl Hannah** (Kennedy’s ex-girlfriend) as a whiny, self-absorbed, cocaine-fueled villain. “These are not creative embellishments of personality,” [Hannah writes](#). “They are assertions about conduct — and they are false.”

America [cannot withstand the economic shock](#) that is coming from A.I., **Gina Raimondo**, a former commerce secretary, argues.

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MORNING READS

Nature's hippies: Researchers learned the hard way that if you give a chimp a crystal — quartz, calcite — [you might not get it back](#).

Your pick: The most-clicked story in The Morning yesterday was [a look inside an East Village apartment](#) that once cost \$110 per month to rent.

Lives Lived: António Lobo Antunes, a prolific Portuguese novelist and one of Europe's most revered writers, [is dead at 83](#).

TODAY'S NUMBER

\$14,199

— *That's roughly how much money, per household, American millennial homeowners spent on renovations last year. [It is more than any other generation](#), even though millennials don't own a majority of homes.*

SPORTS

N.F.L.: The Chicago Bears are [trading wide receiver](#) DJ Moore to the Buffalo Bills, according to league sources, in one of the biggest early offseason moves.

N.B.A.: LeBron James [passed Kareem Abdul-Jabbar](#) for most made field goals in league history. His 15,838th made basket was against the Denver Nuggets.

M.L.S.: Trump [welcomed Inter Miami](#) to the White House to celebrate the team's 2025 M.L.S. Cup title.

RECIPE OF THE DAY



Christopher Testani for The New York Times

Masarepa is a precooked, finely ground corn flour that is the key ingredient in any recipe for [arepas](#), the round, flat and fluffy corn cakes from Venezuela and Colombia. You can find it in most big supermarkets and always online. For this version, Rick A. Martínez griddles the cakes, then splits them open and fills them with a salad of mayo-and-lime-moistened shredded rotisserie chicken and avocado. I like them with butter and queso blanco, too.

ICE QUEEN



Jeremy White/The New York Times

Alysa Liu, the gold medal figure skater, recently spoke with Gia Kourlas, our dance critic, about artistry and the musical choices that put her in her Olympian

flow state.

“The music allows me to get there, which is why it’s so important I skate to music I like,” Liu said. “I know every beat, I know every lyric. My body feels it.”

[Read the whole interview.](#)

More on culture

I’m not sure when I’ll see Maggie Gyllenhaal’s new Frankenstein movie, “The Bride!” But I sure enjoyed reading [Manohla Dargis’s review](#). “It doesn’t always make sense tonally and intellectually,” she writes, “but the whole thing is energetic, handsome and stocked with enough expert, appealing performers to hold your interest through the rougher, less coherent passages.”

Does the world need a new take on Sherlock Holmes? The creators of “Young Sherlock” think so. The streaming series tells the story of the famous detective’s youth with the trademark swagger of the producer Guy Ritchie. [The actor is a Gen Z heartthrob.](#)

Late night hosts [covered Noem’s ouster](#).

THE MORNING RECOMMENDS



Druski Jason Nocito for The New York Times

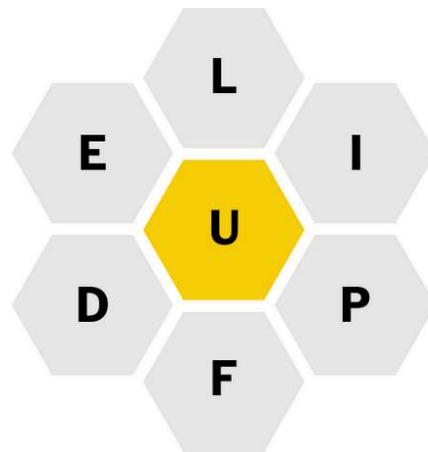
Watch the comedian [Druski's interview](#) with our “Popcast” team. He can’t believe he’s everywhere, either.

Hoover up dust and pet hair with [the best robot vacuum cleaners](#) recommended by the obsessive neatniks at Wirecutter.

Take [our news quiz](#).



GAMES



Here is [today's Spelling Bee](#). Yesterday's pangram was *jocular*.

And here are [today's Mini Crossword](#), [Wordle](#), [Connections](#), [Crossplay](#) and [Strands](#).

*Thanks for spending part of your morning with The Times and me.
See you tomorrow. — Sam*

Reach our team at themorning@nytimes.com.



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